

Bookmarks

Operation	Keystroke	Command	Note
Emacs Bookmarks Native bookmarks - set bookmark - jump to bookmark - insert text via bookmarks - Manage bookmarks - rename/delete bookmark - manage bookmarks via list - save/restore bookmarks bm.el visible bookmarks Last updated on: 2026-09-04	Emacs supports a concept of bookmarks: a position in a file you bookmark and later use a command to quickly move point to that position, even if this is in a different buffer. 💡 Emacs bookmarks support annotations, which can be very useful for document or code analysis and reviews! There's also a set of external packages that extend Emacs bookmarks. PEL supports the following: 📦 The bm.el visible bookmark package. 📄 PEL downloads, installs and activates it when the pel-use-bm user option is set to t. PEL also adds key bindings to several bookmarks commands that have no default key bindings. - All PEL key bindings for bookmarks use the <f11> ' key prefix. - With bm.el visible bookmark active, PEL also binds the <f2> <f2> key sequence to move to the next visible bookmark for quick navigation.		
Open this PDF file. See also: 📖 Help/Info	<f11> ' <f1>	(pel-help-pdf &optional OPEN-WEB-PAGE)	Open the 📖 Bookmarks local PDF. With C–u , M-- , M– –1 or C– –1 prefix: open the remote GitHub hosted PDF instead. If the pel-flip-help-pdf-arg user-option is set it's the other way around.
📖 Customize PEL Bookmark Support	<f11> ' <f2>	(pel-customize-pel &optional OTHER-WINDOW)	Customize PEL Bookmark support: open PEL bookmark support specific group. If OTHER-WINDOW is non-nil (use C–u) , display in other window.
📖 Customize Emacs built-in and external package bookmark support	<f11> ' <f3>	(pel-customize-library &optional OTHER-WINDOW)	Customize Emacs bookmark group which includes: bookmark and bm . When a prefix argument (like C–u) opens the buffer inside another window.
	Group belonging to files that have not yet been loaded are normally not accessible in Emacs and via the customize-group command. PEL, however, attempts to locate the file that defines a non-loaded customization group and will prompt you for loading the file if it finds it.		
Print information about bookmarks control	<f11> ' M-?	(pel-bookmark-info &optional APPEND)	Print bookmark control information in a "pel-bookmark-info" help-mode buffer. - Prints current state and values of relevant user-options as buttons you can use to get more info and change their customized values. - Clears buffer's content by default. Use prefix arg (like C–u) to append instead.
Change current bookmark file	<f11> ' M-f	(pel-bookmark-set-file &optional GLOBALLY)	- Change current bookmark file for the buffer. Prompts for file name. - With prefix arg (like C–u) set the new bookmark file globally: for all buffers.
	💡👉 Use bookmark files for storing annotations about text or code files when you cannot store these annotations inside the file. Later you can use the annotations in the bookmarks to jump back to the corresponding file location. The selected bookmark file setting is not persistent but the content of the file is. The persistent bookmark file is stored in the bookmark-default-file customizable user-option.		
Emacs Native Bookmarks	Emacs native bookmarks are part of the standard Emacs. - Each bookmark has a name you identify which is used to record positions in files. - The bookmarks are saved inside a text file with lisp format. The name of the file is identified by the bookmark-default-file user-option. - The file is created when the first bookmark is set. There are commands to open a buffer that lists the bookmarks where you can delete some. - With PEL type <f11> ' <f3> 1 to access the bookmark customization group to change it.		
Setting a Bookmark	The following commands set Emacs native bookmarks. - Normally each bookmark has a different name, however you can re-use the name of an existing bookmark; the old bookmark value is retained in a stack and the latest bookmark with the name is the one used in jump operations. To retrieve the old value, you must delete the current bookmark with the re-used name. - Each bookmark can also be associated with an annotation. See the bookmark list section below.		
Set a bookmark	C–x r m <f11> ' m	(bookmark-set &optional NAME NO-OVERWRITE)	Set a bookmark named NAME at the current location.
	- With a prefix arg (M–1), do not overwrite any existing bookmark that has the same name as NAME, but instead push the new bookmark onto the bookmark alist. The most recently set bookmark with name NAME is thus the one in effect at any given time, but the others are still there, should the user decide to delete the most recent one. All of those show in the "Bookmark List" view. - To yank words from the text of the buffer and use them as part of the bookmark name, type C–w while setting a bookmark. Successive C–w's yank successive words. - Typing C–u inserts (at the bookmark name prompt) the name of the last bookmark used in the document where the new bookmark is being set; this helps you use a single bookmark name to track progress through a large document. If there is no prior bookmark for this document, C–u inserts an appropriate name based on the buffer or file. - Use <f11> ' d to remove bookmarks (you give it a name and it removes only the first instance of a bookmark with that name from the list of bookmarks.)		
Set a bookmark named BOOKMARK - don't overwrite	C–x r M <f11> ' M	(bookmark-set-no-overwrite &optional NAME PUSH-BOOKMARK)	Set a bookmark named NAME at the current location.
	- If a bookmark named NAME already exists and prefix argument PUSH-BOOKMARK is non-nil, then push the new bookmark onto the bookmark alist. Pushing it means that among bookmarks named NAME, this one becomes the one in effect, but the others are still there, in order, and become effective again if the user ever deletes the most recent one. - Otherwise, if a bookmark named NAME already exists but PUSH-BOOKMARK is nil, raise an error. - To yank words from the text of the buffer and use them as part of the bookmark name, type C–w while setting a bookmark. Successive C–w's yank successive words. - Typing C–u inserts (at the bookmark name prompt) the name of the last bookmark used in the document where the new bookmark is being set; this helps you use a single bookmark name to track progress through a large document. If there is no prior bookmark for this document, then C–u inserts an appropriate name based on the buffer or file. - Use <f11> ' d to remove bookmarks (you give it a name and it removes only the first instance of a bookmark with that name from the list of bookmarks.)		
Jump to a Bookmark	These commands open the file and its location identified by the bookmark in a buffer that is either showing in the current or another window.		
Jump to a bookmark in current window	C–x r b <f11> ' b	(bookmark-jump BOOKMARK &optional DISPLAY-FUNC)	Jump to bookmark BOOKMARK (a point in some file). If the file pointed to by BOOKMARK no longer exists, you will be asked if you wish to give the bookmark a new location, and 'bookmark-jump' will then jump to the new location, as well as recording it in place of the old one in the permanent bookmark record.
Move to a bookmark in other window	<f11> ' B	(bookmark-jump-other-window BOOKMARK)	Jump to BOOKMARK in another window.
Insert text associated with bookmarks	The following commands insert text in the current buffer at point. The first inserts the complete path and file name associated with the identified bookmark. The second inserts the complete text of that file.		
Insert the path of the file to the specified bookmark at the current cursor location	<f11> ' f	(bookmark-insert-location BOOKMARK-NAME &optional NO-HISTORY)	Insert the name of the file associated with BOOKMARK-NAME.
Insert the entire content of bookmarked file	<f11> ' F	(bookmark-insert BOOKMARK-NAME)	Insert the text of the file pointed to by bookmark BOOKMARK-NAME. - BOOKMARK-NAME is a bookmark name (a string), not a bookmark record. - You may have a problem using this function if the value of variable 'bookmark-alist' is nil. If that happens, you need to load in some bookmarks. See function 'bookmark-load' for more about this.

Operation	Keystroke	Command	Note
Manage a single Bookmark	The operations you can do in the bookmark list described above can also be done for a single bookmark with the following two commands. Both of these commands prompt for a bookmark name and support tab completion at the prompt (see ℥ Completion/Input for controlling it).		
• Rename a bookmark	<f11> ' r	(bookmark-rename OLD-NAME &optional NEW-NAME)	Change the name of OLD-NAME bookmark to NEW-NAME name. While you are entering the new name, consecutive C–w's insert consecutive words from the text of the buffer into the new bookmark name.
• Delete a bookmark	<f11> ' d	(bookmark-delete BOOKMARK-NAME &optional BATCH)	Delete BOOKMARK-NAME from the bookmark list. Removes only the first instance of a bookmark with that name. If there are one or more other bookmarks with the same name, they will not be deleted. Defaults to the "current" bookmark (that is, the one most recently used in this file, if any).
List and Manage Bookmarks in the *Bookmark List* buffer.	The following command is used to list and manage the bookmarks you currently have. The bookmark list is shown in a "Bookmark List" buffer. This list each bookmark name and file target on a line. The list of commands you can execute inside the "Bookmark List" buffer is listed below. - Then you can move to the line of the bookmark of interest and jump to the identified location with f, j or <RET>. - You can mark one or several bookmarks with m then use v to open the bookmarked files locations in as many buffers as required. - Note that you can annotate each bookmark. First use the e command to create or edit the annotation: - this opens a "Bookmark Annotation Compose" buffer where you can write you annotation and save it (with C–c C–c). - bookmarks with annotations are marked with a "*" prefix in the "Bookmark List" buffer. - You can also display the text of one annotation or all of them with a or A respectively (but you can't modify them with those). - You can also flag one or several bookmarks for deletion with d, k or C–d and then delete them with x.		
• List bookmarks	C–x r l <f11> ' l	(bookmark-bmenu-list) (list-bookmarks)	Display a list of existing bookmarks. - The list is displayed in a buffer named "Bookmark List". - The leftmost column displays a D if the bookmark is flagged for deletion, or > if it is flagged for displaying.
• *Bookmark List* buffer keys  Annotate bookmarks! - Display Annotations ➡ - Create/Edit Annotation ➡	f or j or <RET> : Go to bookmark on the current line C–o or o : Open the bookmark in other window d, k or C–d : Flag bookmark for deletion r : Rename bookmark s : Save all bookmark listed m : Mark bookmarks to be displayed in multiple windows v : Display marked bookmarks or display the one on the cursor (if none is marked) t : Toggle display of paths to files associated with bookmarks w : Display location of file associated with bookmarks in the mini buffer x : Delete bookmarks flagged for deletion Del : Remove bookmark on previous line or move to the previous line (if there is no mark) Space or n : Move down a line p : Move to previous line l : Load a bookmark file (other than the default) A : Display all annotations a : Display annotation for current bookmark e : Edit (or create) annotation for current bookmark q : Exit a bookmark list		
Saving, Restoring Bookmark in Files	Emacs stores the bookmarks in a common location when it exits. You can also save the bookmarks manually using the following commands. It's also possible to restore bookmarks stored in a file. You must be careful to use a file that was originally created with the bookmark save commands.		
Save bookmarks to standard file	<f11> ' s	(bookmark-save &optional ARG FILE)	Save currently defined bookmarks. - Saves by default in the file defined by the variable 'bookmark-default-file'. Typically the file bookmarks in your Emacs configuration directory (can be customized). - With a prefix arg, save it in file FILE (second argument).
Save all bookmarks to specified file	<f11> ' w	(bookmark-write)	Write bookmarks to a file specified at the prompt.
Load bookmarks from specified file	<f11> ' l	(bookmark-load FILE &optional OVERWRITE NO-MSG)	Load bookmarks from FILE (which must be in bookmark format). - Appends loaded bookmarks to the front of the list of bookmarks. If optional second argument OVERWRITE is non-nil, existing bookmarks are destroyed. Optional third arg NO-MSG means don't display any messages while loading.  If you load a file that doesn't contain a proper bookmark alist, you will corrupt Emacs's bookmark list. Generally, you should only load in files that were created with the bookmark functions in the first place. Your own personal bookmark file, specified by the variable 'bookmark-default-file', is maintained automatically by Emacs; you shouldn't need to load it explicitly. - If you load a file containing bookmarks with the same names as bookmarks already present in your Emacs, the new bookmarks will get unique numeric suffixes "<2>", "<3>", etc.
Visible Bookmarks	Several <i>third party Emacs Lisp packages</i> support other bookmark mechanisms. - One of them is the Visible Bookmarks package (bm.el). This package is a nice complement to Emacs standard bookmarks; it simply highlights the bookmarked line when the bookmark is set (via bm-toggle) and has 2 commands to move point to the next or previous bookmark. It's a lightweight bookmark mechanism that is often sufficient. The PEL package supports it. The commands and binding are listed below. - These keys are often associated with the same key bindings used in Visual Studio: using the <f2> key. Only one works in a macOS terminal (<f2>) the others only work in the graphical mode. The <f11> bindings using in the PEL package work everywhere.  Require the external visible bookmark package: bm.el that  PEL activates them when the pel-use-bm user option is set to t .		
Show all visible bookmarks	<f11> ' ?	(bm-show-all)	Show bookmarked lines in all buffers.
Toggle visible bookmark	<f11> ' '	(bm-toggle)	Toggle bookmark at point. Set/clear line bookmark highlight.
Move point to next visible bookmark	<f11> ' n <f2> <f2>	(bm-next)	Move point to next visible bookmark.
Move point to previous visible bookmark	<f11> ' p	(bm-previous)	Move point to previous visible bookmark.

Bookmark — References

Topic & Link	Description
GNU Emacs - Bookmarks	Describes the Emacs native bookmarks
EmacsWiki - Book Marks	Overview of bookmarks mechanisms in Emacs
EmacsWiki - Bookmark+	A package that enhances the vanilla Emacs bookmark in many ways. A manual that show a large set of features. Written by Drew Adams and Thierry Volpiatto.
M-x all-things-emacs — Bookmark Mania	A small blog giving an overview of 3 bookmark packages.
GitHub — Visible Bookmarks	The visible bookmarks package repository